



DELHI

Makeover Manifesto

It was a carrot and stick performance by BJP chief Nitin Gadkari at the recently concluded National Council in Indore as his inaugural address showed glimpses of a new tough guy side. Gadkari thundered that everyone's "confidential report" would be written "only on the basis of your performance, on how active you are in the field". It now remains to be seen whether he will match his words with action. Gadkari's aggressive posture will be tested next month when his new team is picked. Will he ignore mutually estranged leaders like Arun Jaitley, Sushma Swaraj, Venkaiah Naidu and Ananth Kumar who are well entrenched at 11 Ashoka Road and are likely to demand key posts? Will his party marry Gadkari's rss-type Utopian vision with plans that can match Rahul Gandhi's Youth Brigade? The meet was crucial as it marked the start of the BJP's post Advani-Vajpayee era and opened Gadkari's innings. Recent debacles were firmly blamed on power-greedy leaders. The party also needs to motivate the average BJP worker who is disappointed with the leadership's poor response on the Hindutva agenda. Outgoing party president Rajnath Singh aptly reminded the massive gathering, "We can leave our core agenda in the cold at our own peril." Gadkari's beginning may look solid but the road ahead is surely bumpy.

(L-R) RAJNATH, JAITLEY, L.K. ADVANI, SWARAJ, GADKARI AND MURLI MANOHAR JOSHI

by Uday Mahurkar

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per cent increase in voteshare over the 2009 figure is BJP chief Gadkari's target. That is what the BJP needs for victory in the next general elections.